# Making Friends with Girls

## By Jenny Lawson

**JENNY:** For the majority of my life I lived with a small, terrible secret: I've never really liked girls. I realize this is stereotypical and hypocritical, since I am one myself, but to be fair, I probably wouldn't choose to hang out with myself if given the option.

It's always been this way. I was too much of an anxious misfit to properly bond with girls when I was young, and I never really got the hang of it. I consoled myself by thinking of how much money I saved on Christmas gifts for friends that I never made. Whenever I hear of women who are still best friends with the girls they went to school with, I always make a mental note to avoid them, because I assume they're compulsive liars.

Even as an adult I had mostly male friends, and I looked at most girls as judgy, cruel, fickle, and likely to borrow your Cabbage Patch doll and never give it back. Victor always pushed me to find girlfriends, but I'd convinced myself that girls are like small bears: cute to look at, but far too dangerous to have lunch with.

This all changed when I discovered blogging and found other people online who were misanthropic misfits like me.

## INTRODUCTION

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**JENNY:** I decided to get out of the house and meet a fellow mom blogger named Laura for lunch, Laura tried to convince me that there were actually interesting and fairly nonjudgmental women who wouldn't make fun of the fact that I often had to hide under tables when I was overwhelmed. I didn't believe her, but I took a deep breath and decided to trust her, because if nothing else, this would be the perfect experiment to prove my theory that most grown women are just as dangerous as the kids on the playground who wouldn't let you play tetherball with them because you didn't have Wonder Woman Underoos.

Over the next two years, I became tentative friends with the bloggers Laura introduced me to, and I was eventually invited to go to a weekend all-girl retreat in California wine country for a small group of bloggers.

A conversation with my sister two days before the event:

**ME:** Okay, I just saw the invitation list, and I'm completely freaked about this party. It's like everyone else there is part of the cheer squad, and I'm that weird girl with the back brace who ate too much glue.

**LAURA:** You need to stop freaking out about this. It's going to be super laid-back and casual, and you need to relax and have fun. Just bring a few pairs of jeans and some shirts and you're set.

**ME:** I don't own any jeans.

**LAURA:** You're a damn liar.

**ME:** How many years have you known me? Have you ever seen me wear jeans?

**LAURA:** Wow. No. There might be something wrong with you.

**ME:** This is exactly what I've been trying to tell you.

**JENNY:** The day before the event: Karen (a wonderful and sweet blogger whom Laura had introduced me to) found out that I didn't own jeans, and decided to have a shopping intervention.

**KAREN:** I can't believe you don't wear jeans. Jeans are fabulous, and crazy comfortable. Ooh. See? Those are cute jeans. You should get them.

**ME:** Mmm. No. My knees look fat in these. You wouldn't understand, because you've always been thin, but when you're fat your kneecaps get tired of supporting all of your weight, and so when you lock your knees they bend backward. That's why I always concentrate really hard on always bending slightly at the knee, so that I don't have fat-girl kneecaps.

**KAREN:** I love you, but I can't even tell you how insane you sound right now. Like, most of the time you're fine, but right now? Totally insane.

**ME:** You probably just weren't listening those other times.

**JENNY:** The first day of the party, on the plane: You know when the captain comes on over the overhead speaker and says, "We're going to take off in a few minutes, but we're going to be without air-conditioning for a bit because we don't have auxiliary power, and we're having problems with one engine so we're going to have to get out on the runway before we can get it started"? That's when you should probably just get off the plane. But I couldn't, because I was too terrified to move, so instead I just asked the guy next to me whether he thought this was some sort of joke. He didn't, and told me it was nothing to worry about. "Yeah," I said, my voice becoming shrill with fear, "but they just said we don't have both engines working. I'm pretty sure two engines are preferable."

He rubbed my hand patronizingly and told me I'd be fine, and I assumed he was hitting on me, so I said, "I'm married." Then he looked at me strangely and said, "Congratulations?" He probably wasn't hitting on me at all. More likely he just wanted me to shut up. Then the stewardess came on the speaker, and instead of saying, "At this time we ask you to turn off any portable equipment," she said, "If you're on a cell phone, tell them good-bye." And I'm all, "Why did she say 'Good-bye' with such an air of finality?" The guy sitting next to me didn't respond. Probably because he knew we weren't going to make it out alive.

Amazingly enough, we landed. I was wearing the jeans Karen had persuaded me to buy, and a 1930s-style black hat that I'd hoped screamed, "I'm a bohemian vintage shopper." Then I realized that there was an orange Target price tag stuck to the back that said "Now $7.48." Awesome. Plus I was very aware how fat my kneecaps looked in these jeans. I needed to lie down.

Pajama-party time. Except it was cold, and I don't own pajamas. Everyone was in adorable matching sets with robes. Our hostess, Maggie, was wearing a red silky robe over what looked to be a wedding dress, and she had fluffy slippers on. She looked like she'd just come from Wardrobe. I was wearing a muumuu with sweatpants on underneath, a giant men's hoodie, and my red confidence wig. I'd started wearing a wig in social situations for several reasons: (1) It makes me feel like someone who isn't terrified of people, and (2) if I really *mess* something up I can excuse myself, pull off the wig, and say, "Who was that weird redhead. The wig is a form of protection, a sort of talisman, allowing me to pretend that I'm anyone else who isn't me. Except that I can't afford an expensive wig, so mostly I just look like I'm pretending to be a cancer patient.

Four a.m. I decided it was late enough in Texas to call [my husband] Victor. But about ten minutes into the call I got attacked by a giant bear. Except not really, but it felt like it. Basically I was on the phone and this big animal walked into the pool area from the forest, and I whispered, "I'M GOING TO BE EATEN BY A COUGAR. Wait, are there cougars in California?" But the animal was edging closer, and although it was dark I could see it didn't have a tail, so I whispered, "Bobcat! I'm going to be attacked by a bobcat. Or a cougar that lost its tail. Probably because it got gnawed off by a vampire. And now it's a vampire cougar. But I said all that in my mind, because I was being quiet so that I wouldn't attract its attention. It looked up, saw me, and then slunk off.

Six a.m.:

**ME:** OH MY GOD, LAURA, WAKE UP. I totally just got attacked by a cougar! . . . It might have been a bobcat.

**LAURA:** YOU SAW A BOBCAT?

**ME:** It was small, though, so probably a baby bobcat. It might have been a house cat. BUT IT WAS ENORMOUS. And it totally looked at me in a threatening way.
[to the ten people eating an early breakfast the next morning]
Did Laura tell you I got attacked by a bear last night?

**EVERYONE:** WHAT?

**LAURA:** She did not get attacked by a bear.

**ME:** Bear . . . cougar. Same difference.

**LAURA:** There was no attack. She's fine.

**ME:** I think someone should ask the owners how many cougars they keep on the property.

**LAURA:** I already asked the owners what it could have been, and they said there are some feral cats around.

**ME:** I'm pretty sure "feral cats" is code for "vampire cougars." [to everyone else who came to breakfast one hour later] So last night I was attacked by Sasquatch. It was like a smaller version of the Loch Ness monster. But on land. So, yeah. It was pretty terrifying.

**JENNY:** No one really responded, but it didn't surprise me, because it's hard to know what to say in those situations.

That morning I found out that we were all going to wine education class. I felt like I was in some kind of finishing school and I'd missed all the prerequisites.

By my tenth glass of wine I started to wonder whether there was something wrong with my palate. Everyone else was marking the wine list with notes like "Pleasant finish. Robust spices." Meanwhile, I was doodling pictures of vampiric cougars. Then I noticed people staring at my doodles, and so I started writing notes next to the wine. Things like "Tastes of NyQuil, but in a good way," and "I can't feel my feet anymore." "Did I leave the garage door open? I wonder whether the cat is on fire. I should probably stop drinking now." Everyone else there had a sophisticated palate. I had one that needed therapy, and possibly an intervention.

The final morning we all sat around by the pool, wrapped in blankets with mussed hair and no makeup, and I listened to the conversations around me the same way I had in high school, but instead of trying to block them out or sneer at them internally, I smiled and nodded. I forced myself to join in and listen to all the

conversations going on around me, rather than hide my head in a book to avoid rejection. And I realized just how awesome girl conversations could be. Random snippets of overheard conversations:

**WOMAN 1:** "You know when you're in Nepal and there are all these Japanese people around and it's two a.m. and you're in a basement and you're trying to find breakfast and suddenly a magician shows up?"

**WOMAN 2:** "Oh, I know exactly what you're talking about."

**WOMAN 3:** "My dad had anger problems, so his doctor recommended he go to mime school to learn how to deal quietly with his emotions. It wasn't until I grew up that I realized that everyone doesn't have this memory of taking mime classes with their angry dad."

**WOMAN 4:** "I don't like mimes. I don't like the fact that they fake a disability."

**WOMAN 3:** "Right? Why stop at mimicking the mute? Where are the clowns pretending to have polio?"

**JENNY:** The final hour: As we all dragged our luggage out to the waiting vans, I looked with a surprising amount of affection on these women who only days ago I would have immediately dismissed as being snobby or mean, but who all turned out to have backstories and struggles just as damaged or bizarre as my own.

I was leaving behind my assumptions that only snobby, rich people liked wine, and that everyone would immediately break into cliques based on who had owned the right kind of underwear. And most important, I was leaving behind the idea I'd been carrying around for years that girls were not to be trusted. Women were great and relatively harmless. It's the four a.m. vampire cougars in the woods you really need to be worried about.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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